



DRIVEWAY CPM ACTIVITY CARDS

12 CARDS · 6 WEEKS · 1 CRITICAL PATH

Plan your driveway project the way pros plan bridges

Critical Path Method (CPM) breaks a project into discrete activities with durations and dependencies, then identifies the longest sequence — the 'critical path' — that drives the total project duration. Print these 12 cards, cut along the dashed lines, lay them on your kitchen table, and physically sequence your project.

12

ACTIVITY CARDS

42

DAYS ON CRITICAL PATH

9

ON CRITICAL PATH

How to use these cards

Critical Path Method (CPM) is the scheduling discipline used to plan everything from highway interchanges to skyscrapers. The same logic works for a one-car driveway — you just have fewer cards.

1. Print and cut

Print pages 4–9 single-sided. Cut along the dashed lines. You'll end up with 12 cards.

2. Sequence

Lay the cards on a table left-to-right in order of dependency. Any card whose 'Predecessor' is '—' starts at Day 0.

3. Add dates

Write a calendar date in the blank box on each card. Start with Activity A's 'Earliest Start' and add the durations.

4. Mark the critical path

Cards marked with a red CRITICAL band must finish on time, or your finish date slides. Float cards (C, G, L) can shift without delaying the project.

5. Track on-site

Bring the cards to site visits. Check off each card as it completes. If a critical card slips, immediately update everything downstream.

WHY CPM FOR YOUR DRIVEWAY? (DATAFORSEO · US · 2026)

'Critical path method' gets 2,900 U.S. Google searches/mo with low competition and a \$14.62 CPC — one of the highest CPCs in our category, meaning enterprise project managers actively pay for this content. Applying the same discipline to a residential driveway means you finish on schedule, on budget, and with fewer change orders.

CPM GLOSSARY

Activity: A discrete piece of work with a clear start and end (one card).

Predecessor: An activity that must finish before this one can start.

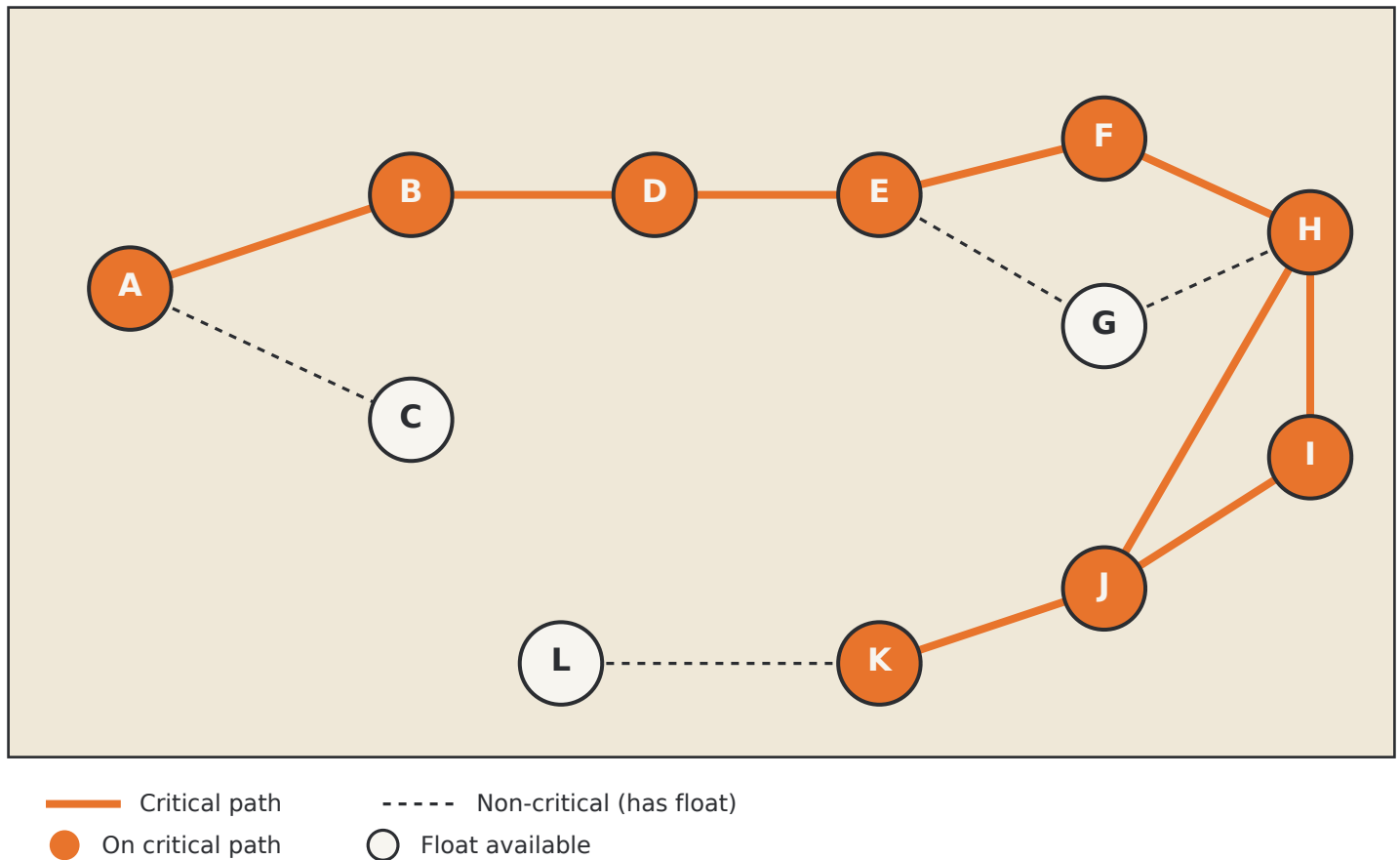
Duration: Working days the activity takes — not calendar days (weekends excluded).

Critical path: The longest chain of dependent activities — drives total project length.

Float / slack: How many days an activity can slip without delaying project finish.

The critical path

Below is the dependency network for a typical residential driveway. The thick orange line traces the critical path: 9 activities, 42 working days (~6 weeks). Off-path activities (C, G, L) have built-in float — they can slip a day or two without slipping the finish date.



Critical path: A → B → D → E → F → H → I → J → K

Total duration on critical path: 42 working days (~6 weeks). Off-path: C, G, L.

A**Scope, Quotes & Contract**

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION**21d****PREDECESSOR(S)**

—

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Homeowner · contractor candidates · finance

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Locks scope, material, budget. Nothing downstream can start until contract signed.

ON-SITE NOTES

Get 3 itemized bids. Sign contract with line items, payment milestones, warranty in writing. Schedule depends entirely on this — 'we'll figure it out later' kills timelines.

STATUS:☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED

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B**Permits & 811 Locate**

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION**14d****PREDECESSOR(S)****A****EARLIEST START**

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Building dept · DOT (if state road) · 811 utility marking

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Cannot dig until 811 marks utilities (2-3 business days). Building permit often required.

ON-SITE NOTES

Submit permit application same day contract signs. Call 811 at least 3 business days before scheduled excavation. Post permit visibly on site.

STATUS:☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED



HOA / Site Plan Approval

OFF CRITICAL PATH — HAS FLOAT

DURATION

10d

PREDECESSOR(S)

A

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

HOA architectural committee · site plan / survey

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Runs parallel with permits (B). If HOA rejects, scope changes and Activity A re-opens.

ON-SITE NOTES

Submit drawings, color, material samples. HOA meetings are often monthly — miss one and you slip 30 days. Float available: ~4 days if started Day 1.

STATUS:

☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED

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Demolition & Haul-Away

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

2d

PREDECESSOR(S)

B

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Excavator · dump truck · disposal facility

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Must follow permits + 811. Concrete/asphalt demo costs more than gravel removal.

ON-SITE NOTES

Document tonnage hauled — line item in contract. Old asphalt can often be recycled (rebate). Stage dumpster on plywood to protect lawn.

STATUS:

☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED

E**Excavation & Sub-Grade Prep**

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

2d

PREDECESSOR(S)

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

D**RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT**

Excavator · skid steer · laser level · soil compactor

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Triggers drainage routing decisions. If soil is worse than expected, Activity F base depth increases and cost goes up.

ON-SITE NOTES

Measure depth with tape after dig — confirm matches contract spec. Photograph soft spots. Compact sub-grade to 95% Proctor density before base.

STATUS:☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED

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F**Base / Sub-Base Install**

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

2d

PREDECESSOR(S)

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

E**RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT**

Crusher run #57 (or spec) · vibrating plate compactor · grader

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Drainage components (G) must be installed during or before this layer.

ON-SITE NOTES

Residential standard: 6" minimum compacted base for asphalt; 4" for concrete. Compact in 2-inch lifts. This is where cheap contractors cut corners.

STATUS:☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED



Drainage Components

OFF CRITICAL PATH — HAS FLOAT

DURATION

1d

PREDECESSOR(S)

E

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Channel drain · French drain · pipe · gravel filter

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Embedded inside base layer (F). If forgotten, you're tearing it back out within a year.

ON-SITE NOTES

Slope: 1-2% away from house minimum. Test water flow with a hose before surface goes down. Float: 1 day if started Day 1 of base prep.

STATUS:

☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED

× cut here ×



Surface Layer Install

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

1d

PREDECESSOR(S)

F · G

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Paver / concrete truck / paver crew · roller · finishing tools

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Weather-dependent (dry, >50°F for asphalt, >40°F for concrete). One day of bad weather slides everything downstream by a day.

ON-SITE NOTES

Asphalt: 2.5-3" compacted, delivered at 275-300°F. Concrete: 5" thick min, 4,000 PSI. Roll asphalt while still hot. For pavers: edge restraint before joint sand.

STATUS:

☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED

**Apron & Curb Cut Finishing**

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

1d

PREDECESSOR(S)

H

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Form work · finishing crew · DOT-spec mix if state road

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Often inspected separately by city/state. A failed apron inspection blocks final sign-off.

ON-SITE NOTES

Apron transition must be smooth — no lips or gaps. Score control joints in concrete. If state right-of-way, DOT inspector may need to be on site.

STATUS: ☐ NOT STARTED ☐ IN PROGRESS ☐ COMPLETE ☐ SLIPPED

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**Initial Cure / Set**

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

3d

PREDECESSOR(S)

H · I

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Time · weather · barricades

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

No vehicles. Light foot traffic only after 24 hrs (concrete) or 48 hrs (asphalt). Concrete reaches 70% strength at day 7.

ON-SITE NOTES

Asphalt: no driving 24-72 hrs, no heavy load 30 days. Concrete: no driving 7 days. Pavers: drivable next day but joints settle 2 weeks.

STATUS: ☐ NOT STARTED ☐ IN PROGRESS ☐ COMPLETE ☐ SLIPPED

K

Final Inspection & Punch List

CRITICAL PATH — DO NOT DELAY

DURATION

1d

PREDECESSOR(S)

J

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Building inspector · homeowner · contractor walk-through

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Closes the permit. Punch list items must be fixed before final payment is released.

ON-SITE NOTES

Spray with hose: water flows away from house. Note every crack, divot, color variation in writing. Get lien waiver from contractor before paying the final invoice.

STATUS:☐

NOT STARTED

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IN PROGRESS

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COMPLETE

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L

First-Season Maintenance

OFF CRITICAL PATH — HAS FLOAT

DURATION

30d

PREDECESSOR(S)

K

EARLIEST START

EARLIEST FINISH

RESOURCES / WHO + WHAT

Homeowner · sealer (year 1+) · joint sand topup (pavers)

DEPENDENCY LOGIC

Activates warranty. Failing to do month-12 sealcoat (asphalt) often voids warranty.

ON-SITE NOTES

Month 1: hairline crack inspection. Month 6: drainage check after heavy rain. Month 12: first sealcoat (asphalt) or joint refill (pavers). Save all receipts.

STATUS:☐

NOT STARTED

☐

IN PROGRESS

☐

COMPLETE

☐

SLIPPED